

SUPREME COURT OF THE STATE OF NEW YORK
COUNTY OF KINGS

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NEESHA WILLIAMS,

Plaintiff,

-against-

SUMMONS

THE CITY OF NEW YORK, POLICE OFFICER ETHAN
COOLEY, Shield No. 24949, and POLICE OFFICERS
JOHN DOES NUMBERS ONE THROUGH TEN,

Index No.:

The Basis of Venue is:
Location of Incident

Defendants.

Plaintiff designates Kings
County as the place of trial.

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To the above named Defendants:

You are hereby summoned to answer the Verified Complaint in this action, and to serve a copy of your Verified Answer to the Verified Complaint, or, if the Verified Complaint is not served with this Summons, to serve a notice of appearance on the Plaintiff's attorneys within twenty days after the service of this Summons, exclusive of the day of service, where service is made by delivery upon you personally within the state, or, within 30 days after completion of service where service is made in any other manner. In case of your failure to appear or answer, judgment will be taken against you by default for the relief demanded in the complaint.

DATED: New York, New York
December 15, 2019

Yours, etc.

/s/

CAITLIN ROBIN, ESQ.
CAITLIN ROBIN AND ASSOCIATES PLLC
Attorneys for Plaintiff
30 Broad Street Suite 702
New York, New York 10004
(646)-524-6026

TO: THE CITY OF NEW YORK, Corporation Counsel, 100 Church Street, NY, NY 10007

POLICE OFFICER ETHAN COOLEY, Shield No. 24949, 79 Precinct, 263
Tompkins Avenue, Brooklyn, New York 11216

SUPREME COURT OF THE STATE OF NEW YORK
COUNTY OF KINGS

----- X

NEESHA WILLIAMS,

INDEX NO.:

Plaintiff, VERIFIED COMPLAINT

-against-

THE CITY OF NEW YORK, POLICE OFFICER ETHAN
COOLEY, Shield No. 24949, and POLICE OFFICERS
JOHN DOES NUMBERS ONE THROUGH TEN,

JURY TRIAL DEMANDED

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Plaintiff NEESHA WILLIAMS, by her attorneys, Caitlin Robin & Associates, PLLC, as
and for her Verified Complaint herein, alleges upon information and belief as follows:

PRELIMINARY STATEMENT

1. This is a civil rights action to recover money damages arising out of defendants' violation of plaintiff's rights as secured by the Civil Rights Act, 42 U.S.C. Sections 1983 and 1988, and of rights secured by the Fourth, Fifth and Fourteenth Amendments to the United States Constitution, and the common law and the laws of the State of New York. On July November 2, 2018, at approximately 4:00 p.m., plaintiff Neesha Williams, while lawfully in the vicinity of 280 Herkimer Street, Brooklyn, New York, was subject to an unlawful stop, question, frisk, search, false arrest, and false imprisonment by the defendant New York City police officers. Plaintiff was then unlawfully imprisoned at the 79th Precinct Police Station and Kings County Central Booking for approximately 35 hours until the King's County District Attorney's Office declined to prosecute Plaintiff, and she was released from custody. Plaintiff was denied the right to due process and a fair trial until the arrest charges against plaintiff were dismissed on November 3, 2019. Plaintiff was deprived of her constitutional and common law rights when the individual defendants unlawfully stopped, questioned, frisked, searched, confined, falsely arrested, falsely imprisoned, and denied plaintiff the right to due process and a fair trial in violation of the Fourth, Fifth and Fourteenth Amendments to the United States Constitution, the common law and the laws of the State of New York.

PARTIES

2. Plaintiff NEESHA WILLIAMS is a resident of the state of New York.
3. POLICE OFFICER ETHAN COOLEY, Shield No. 24949, is and was at all times relevant herein, an officer, employee, and agent of the New York City Police Department.
4. POLICE OFFICER ETHAN COOLEY, Shield No. 24949, was at all times relevant herein, assigned to 79th Precinct.
5. POLICE OFFICER ETHAN COOLEY, Shield No. 24949, is being sued in his individual and official capacity.
6. New York City Police Officers John Does #1-10 are and were at all times relevant herein officers, employees, and agents of the New York City Police Department.
7. Police Officers John Does #1-10 are being sued in their individual and official capacities.
8. At all times relevant herein, the individual defendants were acting under color of state law in the course and scope of their duties and functions as agents, servants, employees and officers of the New York City Police Department, and otherwise performed and engaged in conduct incidental to the performance of their lawful functions in the course of their duties. They were acting for and on behalf of the New York City Police Department at all times relevant herein, with the power and authority vested in them as officers, agents and employees of the New York City Police Department and incidental to the lawful pursuit of their duties as officers, employees and agents of the New York City Police Department.
9. Defendant City of New York is a municipal entity created and authorized under the laws of the State of New York. It is authorized by law to maintain a police department, which acts as its agent in the area of law enforcement and for which it is ultimately responsible. The defendant City of New York assumes the risks incidental to the maintenance of a police force and the employment of police officers as said risks attach to the public consumers of the services provided by the New York City Police Department.
10. Plaintiff in furtherance of his causes of action brought pursuant to New York State law filed a timely Notice of Claim against the CITY OF NEW YORK in compliance with the Municipal Law Section 50 and in accordance with New York State law.
11. In accordance with New York State law and General Municipal Law Section 50, plaintiff testified at a hearing held pursuant to General Municipal Law Section 50-H April 11, 2019.

12. More than thirty (30) days have elapsed since service of said Notice of Claim was filed and THE CITY OF NEW YORK has failed to pay or adjust the claims.

13. This action falls within one or more of the exceptions as set forth in CPLR Section 1602, involving intentional actions, as well as the defendant, and/or defendants, having acted in reckless disregard for the safety of others, as well as having performed intentional acts.

14. Plaintiff has sustained damages in an amount in excess of the jurisdictional limits of all the lower Courts of the State of New York.

STATEMENT OF FACTS

15. On November 2, 2019, at approximately 4:00 p.m., plaintiff was lawfully present in the vicinity of 280 Herkimer Street, Kings County, New York, when the defendant police officers unlawfully stopped, questioned, frisked, and falsely arrested plaintiff without probable cause or legal justification.

16. Plaintiff was getting a ride from her mother's house to therapy from her friend.

17. Plaintiff left her mother's house and got into a vehicle with her friend to go to therapy.

18. The car started driving, and was pulled over almost immediately by the Defendant Officers.

19. The Defendant Officers ordered everyone to give their identifications and get out of the vehicle.

20. Plaintiff obeyed the Defendant Officers orders, gave her identification, and exited the vehicle.

21. Defendant Police Officers handcuffed Plaintiff, without permission or authority, and began searching her person.

22. No contraband or anything illegal was found on Plaintiff.

23. At no time relevant herein did plaintiff commit a crime or violate the law in any way, nor did the police officer have an objective reason to accuse plaintiff committing a crime or violating the law in any way.

24. At no point did defendants recover any drugs, weapons, or other illegal contraband from plaintiff or from a location that was in plaintiff's possession, custody or control.

25. Nevertheless, plaintiff was unlawfully arrested and handcuffed by defendant officers without legal justification or probable cause.

26. Plaintiff did not resist arrest.

27. Plaintiff repeatedly asked Defendant Officers what she was being arrested for, and they refused to tell her.

28. Defendants transported plaintiff to the 73rd Precinct Precinct police station against her will, where plaintiff was unlawfully photographed, fingerprinted and detained in a holding cell.

29. Plaintiff was then transported to King's County Central Booking.

30. Plaintiff was still unaware what she was being charged with.

31. The defendant police officers provided the District Attorney's Office with the false, misleading and/or incomplete information that plaintiff committed a crime.

32. Specifically, the defendant police officers falsely stated to the District Attorney's Office that plaintiff was engaged in criminal acts.

33. On November 3, 2019, at approximately 11:00 p.m., after 30 hours in unlawful custody, the King's County District Attorney's Office declined to prosecute Plaintiff.

34. Plaintiff was released from King's County Central Booking with no charges.

35. Some of the police officer defendants observed the violation of plaintiff's rights under the Constitution of the United States and New York State Law and did nothing to prevent their fellow officers from unjustifiably searching, seizing, assaulting, battering, using excessive force, falsely arresting and imprisoning, and denying plaintiff the right to due process and a fair trial

36. The unlawful, search, seizure, assault, battery, use of excessive force, false arrest and imprisonment, and denial of plaintiff's right to a fair trial by the individually named defendants caused plaintiff to sustain physical, psychological and emotional trauma.

FIRST CAUSE OF ACTION

Violation of Plaintiff's Fourth and Fourteenth Amendment Rights

37. The plaintiff repeats, reiterates and realleges each and every allegation contained in paragraphs marked 1 through 36 with the same force and effect as if more fully set forth at length herein.

38. The individually named police officer defendants while acting in concert and within the scope of their authority, caused plaintiff to be seized, unlawfully searched, falsely arrested, and falsely imprisoned, and maliciously prosecuted without reasonable suspicion and/or probable cause, in violation of plaintiff's right to be free of an unreasonable seizure under the Fourth Amendment of the Constitution of the United States and to be free of a deprivation of liberty under the Fourteenth Amendment to the Constitution of the United States.

39. As a result of the aforementioned conduct of defendants, plaintiff sustained injuries, including but not limited to physical, emotional, psychological and economic injuries.

SECOND CAUSE OF ACTION

False Arrest and False Imprisonment

40. The plaintiff repeats, reiterates and realleges each and every allegation contained in paragraphs marked 1 through 39 with the same force and effect as if more fully set forth at length herein.

41. The acts and conduct of the defendants constitute false arrest and false imprisonment under the laws of the State of New York. Defendants intended to confine plaintiff and, in fact, confined plaintiff, and plaintiff was conscious of the confinement. In addition, plaintiff did not consent to the confinement and the confinement was not otherwise privileged.

42. As a direct and proximate result of such acts, defendants deprived plaintiff of his rights under the laws of the State of New York and the United States Constitution.

43. Defendants were at all times agents, servants, and employees acting within the scope of their employment by the City of New York and the New York City Police Department, which are therefore responsible for their conduct.

44. The City, as the employer of the officer defendants, is responsible for their wrongdoing under the doctrine of *respondeat superior*.

45. As a result of the aforementioned conduct of defendants, plaintiff sustained injuries, including but not limited to physical, economic, emotional and psychological injuries.

THIRD CAUSE OF ACTION

Unlawful Stop, Question, and Frisk

46. The plaintiff repeats, reiterates and realleges each and every allegation contained in paragraphs marked 1 through 45 with the same force and effect as if more fully set forth at length herein.

47. The illegal approach, pursuit, stop, questioning and frisk employed by defendants herein terminated plaintiff's freedom of movement through means intentionally applied.

48. The conduct of defendants in stopping, frisking, and searching plaintiff was performed under color of law and without any reasonable suspicion of criminality or other constitutionally required grounds.

49. As a direct and proximate result of such acts, defendants deprived plaintiff of her rights under the laws of the State of New York.

50. Defendants were at all times agents, servants, and employees acting within the scope of their employment by the City of New York and the New York City Police Department, which are therefore responsible for their conduct.

51. The City, as the employer of the officer defendants, is responsible for their wrongdoing under the doctrine of *respondeat superior*.

FOURTH CAUSE OF ACTION

Unlawful Search

52. The plaintiff repeats, reiterates and realleges each and every allegation contained in paragraphs marked 1 through 51 with the same force and effect as if more fully set forth at length herein.

53. The illegal approach, pursuit, stop and search employed by defendants herein terminated plaintiff's freedom of movement through means intentionally applied.

54. Defendants lacked probable cause to search plaintiff.

55. As a direct and proximate result of such acts, defendants deprived plaintiff of her rights under the laws of the State of New York.

56. Defendants were at all times agents, servants, and employees acting within the scope of their employment by the City of New York and the New York City Police Department, which are therefore responsible for their conduct.

57. The City, as the employer of the officer defendants, is responsible for their wrongdoing under the doctrine of *respondeat superior*.

58. As a result of the aforementioned conduct of defendants, plaintiff sustained injuries, including but not limited to emotional and psychological injuries.

FIFTH CAUSE OF ACTION

Violation of Plaintiff's Fifth and Fourteenth Amendment Rights

Denial of Right to Fair Trial/Due Process

59. The plaintiff repeats, reiterates and realleges each and every allegation contained in paragraphs marked 1 through 58 with the same force and effect as if more fully set forth at length herein

60. Defendants, individually and collectively, manufactured and/or withheld false evidence and forwarded this false evidence to prosecutors in the King's County District Attorney's Office.

61. Defendants filled out false and misleading police reports and forwarded them to prosecutors in the King's County District Attorney's Office.

62. Defendants signed false and misleading criminal court affidavits and forwarded them to prosecutors in the King's County District Attorney's Office.

63. In withholding/creating false evidence against plaintiff, and in providing/withholding information with respect thereto, defendants violated plaintiff's constitutional right to due process and fair trial under the New York State Constitution and under the Due Process Clause of the Fifth Amendment to the Constitution of the United States and to be free to deprivation of liberty under the Fourteenth Amendment to the United States Constitution.

64. As a result of the foregoing, plaintiff NEESHA WILLIAMS, sustained, inter alia, loss of the right to due process and a fair trial, loss of liberty, emotional distress, embarrassment and humiliation, lost earnings and deprivation of her constitutional rights.

65. Defendants were at all times agents, servants, and employees acting within the scope of their employment by the City of New York and the New York City Police Department, which are therefore responsible for their conduct.

66. The City, as the employer of the officer defendants, is responsible for their wrongdoing under the doctrine of *respondeat superior*.

67. As a result of the aforementioned conduct of defendants, plaintiff sustained injuries, including but not limited to emotional and psychological injuries.

SIXTH CAUSE OF ACTION

Malicious Prosecution

68. The plaintiff repeats, reiterates and realleges each and every allegation contained in paragraphs marked 1 through 67 with the same force and effect as if more fully set forth at length herein.

69. The acts and conduct of the defendants constitute malicious prosecution under the laws of the State of New York and New York State common law.

70. Defendants commenced and continued a criminal proceeding against plaintiff.

71. There was actual malice and an absence of probable cause for the criminal proceeding against plaintiff and for each of the charges for which she was prosecuted.

72. The prosecution and criminal proceedings terminated in plaintiff's favor on the aforementioned dates.

73. Plaintiff was subjected to a post-arraignment deprivation of liberty sufficient to implicate plaintiff's Fourth Amendment rights.

74. As a direct and proximate result of such acts, defendants deprived plaintiff of her rights under the laws of the State of New York and the United States Constitution.

75. The City, as the employer of the officer defendants, is responsible for their wrongdoing under the doctrine of *respondeat superior*.

76. As a result of the aforementioned conduct of defendants, plaintiff sustained injuries, including but not limited to emotional and psychological injuries.

SEVENTH CAUSE OF ACTION

Negligent Infliction of Emotional Distress

77. The plaintiff repeats, reiterates and realleges each and every allegation contained in paragraphs marked 1 through 76 with the same force and effect as if more fully set forth at length herein.

78. By the actions described herein, defendants, each acting individually and in concert with each other, engaged in extreme and outrageous conduct, conduct utterly intolerable in a civilized community, which negligently caused severe emotional distress to plaintiff. The acts and conduct of the defendants were the direct and proximate cause of injury and damage to plaintiff and violated plaintiff's statutory and common law rights as guaranteed by the laws and Constitution of the State of New York.

79. The acts and conduct of the defendants were the direct and proximate cause of injury and damage to plaintiff and violated plaintiff's statutory and common law rights as guaranteed plaintiff by the laws and Constitution of the State of New York.

80. As a direct and proximate result of such acts, defendants deprived plaintiff of her rights under the laws of the State of New York.

81. Defendants were at all times agents, servants, and employees acting within the scope of their employment by the City of New York and the New York City Police Department, which are therefore responsible for their conduct.

82. The City, as the employer of the officer defendants, is responsible for their wrongdoing under the doctrine of *respondeat superior*.

83. As a result of the aforementioned conduct of defendants, plaintiff sustained injuries, including but not limited to emotional and psychological injuries.

EIGHTH CAUSE OF ACTION

Negligent Hiring, Retention, Training and Supervision

84. The plaintiff repeats, reiterates and realleges each and every allegation contained in paragraphs marked 1 through 83 with the same force and effect as if more fully set forth at length herein.

85. The City of New York and its employees, servants and/or agents acting within the scope of their employment did negligently hire, retain, train and supervise defendants, individuals who were unfit for the performance of police duties on the aforementioned dates at the aforementioned locations.

86. As a result of the aforementioned conduct of defendants, plaintiff sustained injuries, including but not limited to emotional and psychological injuries.

NINTH CAUSE OF ACTION

Failure to Intervene

87. The plaintiff repeats, reiterates and realleges each and every allegation contained in paragraphs marked 1 through 86 with the same force and effect as if more fully set forth at length herein.

88. The defendants that did not physically touch plaintiff, but were present when other officers violated plaintiff's Constitutional Rights had an affirmative duty to intervene on behalf of plaintiff, whose constitutional rights were being violated in their presence by other officers.

89. Defendants failed to intervene to prevent the unlawful conduct described herein.

90. As a result of the foregoing, plaintiff's liberty was restricted for an extended period of time, she was put in fear of her safety, and she was humiliated and subject to other physical constraints.

91. As a direct and proximate result of such acts, defendants deprived plaintiff of her rights under the laws of the State of New York.

92. Defendants were at all times agents, servants, and employees acting within the scope of their employment by the City of New York and the New York City Police Department, which are therefore responsible for their conduct.

93. The City, as the employer of the officer defendants, is responsible for their wrongdoing under the doctrine of *respondeat superior*.

94. As a result of the aforementioned conduct of defendants, plaintiff sustained injuries, including but not limited to emotional and psychological injuries.

JURY DEMAND

95. Plaintiff hereby demands trial by jury of all issues properly triable thereby.

PRAYER FOR RELIEF

WHEREFORE, plaintiff NEESHA WILLIAMS demands judgment against the defendants on each cause of action in amounts to be determined upon the trial of this action which exceeds the jurisdiction of lower courts, inclusive of punitive damages and attorneys' fees inclusive of costs and disbursements of this action, interest and such other relief as is appropriate under the law. That the plaintiff recover the cost of the suit herein, including reasonable attorney's fees pursuant to 42 U.S.C. § 1988.

Dated: New York, New York
December 15, 2019

By: /s/

CAITLIN ROBIN, ESQ.
CAITLIN ROBIN AND ASSOCIATES PLLC
Attorney for Plaintiff
30 Broad Street Suite 702
New York, New York 10004
(646)-524-6026

TO: THE CITY OF NEW YORK, Corporation Counsel, 100 Church Street, NY, NY 10007
POLICE OFFICER ETHAN COOLEY, Shield No. 24949, 79 Precinct, 263
Tompkins Avenue, Brooklyn, New York 11216

ATTORNEY'S VERIFICATION

CAITLIN ROBIN, an attorney duly admitted to practice before the Courts of the State of New York, affirms the following to be true under the penalties of perjury:

I am a member of the law firm of **CAITLIN ROBIN AND ASSOCIATES PLLC**, I have read the annexed **VERIFIED COMPLAINT** and know the contents thereof, and the same are true to my knowledge, except those matters therein which are stated to be alleged upon information and belief, and as to those matters I believe them to be true. My belief, as to those matters therein not stated upon knowledge, is based upon facts, records, and other pertinent information contained in my files. The reason this verification is made by me and not Plaintiff is because plaintiff does not reside in the county wherein I maintain my office.

DATED: New York, New York
December 15, 2019

/s/
CAITLIN ROBIN